

CD Writing

The Moser Baer drive was the quickest in the CD-R write test, followed closely by the Sony DRU-190A and Samsung. ASUS drives were the slowest and this is attributed largely due to the media compatibility issues that they face. Sony, Samsung and Philips drives were quicker in writing to CD-RW media.

DVD Writing

The Philips SPD2514T was the found to be the fastest in assorted DVD-R writes, though not by an especially large margin; it was closely trailed by the Sony and Samsung drives. The Moser Baer and Sony DRU-845S were the fastest in sequential DVD-R write test, taking just seven seconds over five minutes. The Philips and Samsung were close behind. Media compatibility issues dogged the ASUS drives as they delivered considerably slower performance. Coming to DVD+R writing, we found that it was the Samsung drive that outperformed all the other drives this time, and by a commanding margin. The slowest drives were yet again the ASUS drives, but the performance difference was not as much as in the case of DVD-R writing. Writing to dual layer media did not change the picture, the only difference was that the Moser Baer drive could not keep up with its earlier performance. But in general, there was not a huge difference between the performance of the drives in this case, the leaders here were Philips, Samsung, and Sony drives.

Winners

If we took a look at raw performance, most of the drives did fairly well. We took a final call by taking into consideration, the price. There was a huge difference between the prices of DVD Writers—some were priced at a high of around Rs 3,000, while some were priced as low as Rs 1,200. The price was therefore, the decider.

Trailing behind the Samsung, the Sony DRU-845S misses out from topping the performance chart by just a whisker. It comes with a decent bundle of Nero 7 Essential and also a black bezel that lets you match its appearance with your PC cabinet. Boasting of dual layer DVD write speeds of 12x and priced at just Rs 1,600, this drive deserves a special mention here.

Moser Baer was next in line, along with the Sony DRU-190A—both these drives performed well and were priced well too. Although the Philips drives performed well—better than the other drives in some tests—their prices are unreasonably high, and that

Editor's Pick



Samsung SH-S203
The best of all!

The award for the Editor's Pick as well as the Best Performer were swept up by the Samsung SH-S203. It sports 20x writing speeds for DVD+R and DVD-R and we were surprised to see that it can write to dual layer DVD+Rs at 16x! Without any exceptions, this drive delivers top-notch performance and tops the chart in all the writing and reading tests with all kinds of media. It took just over five minutes to burn 4.38 GB data to the DVDs, in both the assorted and sequential test. It completes burning a 700 MB CD in less than 170 seconds. It excels in the reading tests too, with a score of 12.14x in Nero DVD Speed. The price of this drive is the lowest amongst the lot—just Rs.1,200 and yet it comes with a great bundle that includes SATA data and power cable as well as Nero Express 7 suite, which includes DVD playback, data backup as well as video encoding software. We were left with no choice but to award all the awards to the Samsung SH-S203.

is the reason why they ended up at the bottom end of the chart.

Closing Thoughts

As we have seen, there is not too much that sets these DVD Writers apart, especially in terms of writing speeds. What does differ is the prices and the warranty and service offered. Now we can't test how long these drives will last, but warranty is something you should keep your eyes open for.

With falling prices, combo drives (DVD-ROM/CD writer) have all but disappeared, and you should refrain from buying one—stick to DVD writers. Also, because optical drive read and write speeds are a lot slower than hard drives, the performance difference between writers based on interface—SATA or IDE—is negligible. Most newer motherboards will have enough SATA ports, so you can safely opt for a SATA DVD writer—the difference lies not in the performance, but in the cable clutter. SATA cables being thinner, your cabinet can do without wide IDE cables getting in the way of everything.

The optical drive market is in turmoil because of the stalemate between the Blu-ray and HD-DVD camps. With more movie studios preferring Blu-ray, it could be the format of the future. This will be good for us consumers, because finally manufacturers will pick a side and prices will start to plummet. Only time will tell though, and unfortunately, for now, Blu-ray drives remain a rarity, and quite expensive. ■

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